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A GREEN CARPET ROLLED OUT TO NATURE ENTHUSIASTS

Bushwalk corridor, a community-built green space along the Buckingham Canal serves as a venue for guided bushwalks and birding sessions **P4**



SANTHOME CRICKET LORE NEVER RUNS OUT OF FIZZ

The 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School will be in the spotlight today, its members having a gala Golden Jubilee Reunion on the campus **P6**

Thiruvannamiyur's Thirty

Young residents of the locality, those in the age group of 8 to 24, have joined hands to lead change and progress. Thiruvannamiyur Young Changemakers Club had its first meeting on June 6



During a plogging activity by residents of Thiruvannamiyur.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

PRINCE FREDERICK

Largely in circulation only in recent times, the compound word "changemaker" cannot be hoary-haired. "Young changemakers", a qualified form of it, is of even more recent prevalence, and one would imagine it coming with a raven-black mop of hair, particularly in most Indian contexts. But

the idea of youngsters as changemakers is no spring chicken. That idea has been hopping around around for a long time, has even been deified in literature. Enid Blyton presented a bunch of five young changemakers, famously known as, well, *Famous Five*. She would present another bunch, *The Secret Seven*. The list across literature is long, probably crowned by J.K. Rowling's brainchild Harry Potter. The idea that youngsters

can do things beyond their years for the common good displaying integrity and courage is hard-wired into the human mind.

The idea recently gained more ground, taking a generous patch of land along the Chennai coast: the whole of Thiruvannamiyur. At the time of this article going to print on June 6, preparations were under way for the first meetup of Thiruvannamiyur Young Changemakers Club.

Based on the registrations, 30 young changemakers were inducted into the club when the day ended. The change the Club is expected to work towards comes with multiple layers, the most obvious ones being social, civic and environmental. As with all young changemaker stories, in real life and in fiction, this one has adult authors scripting it. The idea reportedly germinated at Valmiki Nagar in Thiruvannamiyur, where a group of residents were brainstorming on how to reverse certain initiatives out of the frustrating cul-de-sac they had slid into. Gayatri Nair, a resident of Third Seaward Road and a prime mover in this effort, being one of the adults scripting this story of change, says the idea was to infuse fresh energy into flagging community-driven initiatives such as beach and street clean-ups, plogging, waste segregation, preservation of trees and care for Thiruvannamiyur beach.

One suggestion that resonated with everyone was the establishment of a young group that would shoulder these responsibilities, not single-handedly, as the adults would continue to tweak the script whenever necessary. But the youngsters would be given a clear, unmistakable sense of leading the change, having been empowered as decision-making agencies. Gayatri notes the age range for membership in the Club is 8 to 24 years. And the Club would stay Thiruvannamiyur-centric, she states, elaborating people from elsewhere are welcome to study its workings and create their own hyperlocal club with similar focus in their neighbourhoods.

Membership to the club is currently closed as the required number has been reached. Know more about the initiative @changemakers.600041

Cricket tournament at Gandhi Nagar Cricket and Sports Club



The P.S. Nataraja Sarma Memorial Tournament began at Gandhi Nagar Cricket and Sports Club on June 6. The 50 overs-a-side tournament will feature a total of eight teams. The participating teams will consist of class cricketers. All matches are expected to be of high standard and interesting, says a press release. The finals will be held on June 27.

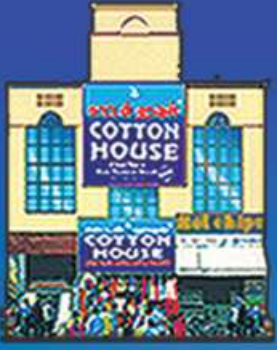
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Will Metro Water ease these foot soldiers' everyday ordeal?

A hand pump at a public square and a community water connection in Sholinganallur need urgent attention

PRINCE FREDERICK

At School Road South in Sholinganallur, a memorial shelter approximates to a public square. Overlooking a pond and shaded by a sprawling banyan tree, the structure essentially meant for the local community to perform 16th day rituals of the deceased, recommends itself as an all-season hangout. And local residents act on that recommendation.

Under the maintenance of Ward 199 in Zone 15 of Greater Chennai Corporation, the structure is a roofed pavilion, largely open on the sides, thereby making for optimal ventilation, a factor encouraging people to have a spot of relaxation in a cloistered environ, particularly during summer.

The space hosting the structure has another utility, designed as an add-on, but comes with an everyday relevance. Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB) had installed a hand pump, and the pump is worked vigorously every day, a



horde of people heading to it with pots; they do not have provisions for direct supply of water to their homes, many of which are hovels.

And the handle is now being worked up and down much harder, but that does not help. The water flow is slow despite the efforts.

School Road South has mixed housing. Apartments with round-the-clock amenities that can be had without raising one's little finger. And on the other hand, the road has pockets that wear blue-collar fatigues as well as present a vignette of the locality's pastoral past, rudely interrupted only around 20 years ago by the Information Technology juggernaut.

Arjunan is running late for work, and the lethargic flow of water is adding to his stress. He is a mason, and every man hour he gives his employer is significant, and the latter would frown on late-coming with a more twisted visage than would a supervisor at an IT company.

Arjunan notes that the water flow is slow for the last two months as the washer needs replacement.

Kuppuswamy, 77 years old, is not in gainful employment, but has

hardly retired to a life of ease and unaccountability. By the look of things, he never will. Under his breath, he mumbles that everyone at home wave their employed status at him, and march him off to the hand pump to fill ten pots of water in the morning.

He is also the baby sitter of the family, having been tasked with taking care of its youngest member while the rest are out earning the daily bread. CMWSSB can ease his burden in the mornings.

For the benefit of a group of low-income households, massed together at one spot, CMWSSB has provided water on tap, one connection for that settlement, but the tap is running dry.

If this provision had been productive, this enervated senior would have been spared the strain of working a stubborn hand pump.

Located at Kalaingar Karunanidhi Salai, the Sholinganallur Zone 15 office (Area XV) is not far from these spots, but the will to make things easy for people whose life is tough on any given day, seems to be light years away.

Kuppuswamy and Arjunan.

A green carpet rolled out to nature enthusiasts

Bushwalk corridor, a community-built green space along the Buckingham Canal behind House of Hiranandani Upscale in Egattur on Old Mahabalipuram Road serves as a venue for guided bushwalks and birding sessions, as it did on World Environment Day

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A patch of burnt soil, damaged drip irrigation pipes and blackened tree trunks now mark a section of what is called Bushwalk corridor along Buckingham Canal in Egattur, thanks to a fire that swept through it roughly a fortnight ago. Residents of House of Hiranandani Upscale had ploughed in considerable resources to build this green corridor, located in the space along the Canal, behind the towers. And they would have to allocate more resources to repair and restore the damaged elements. But this setback did not hold The Bushwalk Trust which manages the corridor from going ahead with a public event on World Environment Day (June 5), a walk down the Bushwalk corridor offered to both residents and guests. From time to time, the 'green' carpet is rolled out to nature enthusiasts from anywhere.

Along the way, the corridor had grown massive enough to make administration by a trust necessary. The corridor supports 12,000 plants and serves as a space for guided bushwalks and birding sessions.

The seeds of a green corridor were sown ironically during a "dry" period, the pandemic. Around 3,000 saplings of Arjuna tree had been planted along the Buckingham canal under a Tamil Nadu government urban forestry initiative. "There was no mechan-



ism to ensure their survival," recalls Shanthi Jothilingam, Treasurer of Bushwalk Trust. "Many residents assumed the agency that planted the saplings would continue maintaining them. But when that did not happen, a few volun-

teers stepped in." Among them was R. Shankar, a resident whose commitment would eventually shape the future of the landscape. Having left his job during the pandemic, Shankar found himself spending more time within the community



Images from the World Environment Day walk at Bushwalk corridor; a male Golden oriole photographed at the corridor.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND E. ARUN KUMAR

and became increasingly concerned about the fate of the saplings.

"We felt that if we did not act at that stage, thousands of saplings would simply be lost," he recalls. Residents pooled in funds, hired water tankers and spent weekends watering the saplings. The terrain was uneven and covered in dense undergrowth, making access difficult. Volunteers often filled drums with water and carried buckets across the site to reach the plants.

"It was physically demanding work," says Shanthi. "People would come before work, after work or whenever they found time and chip in."

Saplings grew, so did the scope of the initiative. Through Exnora International, the group established ties with Gayatri Trust, which later extended financial sup-

port. Around the same time, Shankar identified an opportunity to utilise groundwater emerging from nearby construction activity instead of allowing it to flow into the Buckingham Canal. The water was tested, found suitable for irrigation and channelled into a pond constructed with external support. From there, a drip irrigation system and sprinklers were installed across the site, dramatically reducing dependence on water tankers and creating a more sustainable maintenance model.

As the project expanded, residents realised the initiative needed a formal structure. The Bushwalk Trust was subsequently established as a legally registered trust, enabling it to receive institutional funding, employ dedicated gardeners and manage its finances transparently.

Children are often at the centre of programmes by The Bushwalk Trust. Plantation drives encourage them to plant saplings and monitor their growth, while nature-based activities foster a deeper connection with the environment.

The corridor has also emerged as an unexpected biodiversity hotspot. E. Arun Kumar, a resident naturalist who has been documenting wildlife in the area since 2021, says the habitat now supports a rich variety of resident and migratory bird species.

"We have documented 176 bird species here," he says. "Every few months, we organise bird walks, particularly during winter when migratory birds arrive. Many children who attend develop a lasting interest in birdwatching and nature."



Shelter at Anna University bus stop **needs mending**



The precariously hanging bus route number boards at the Anna University haltover.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Waiting at Anna University stop (on the lane towards Guindy) should get one's safety antennas up.

The roof of the shelter is torn,

and the structure leans forward. Furthermore, the stainless-steel structure supporting the roof is rusty. A row of boards denoting the route numbers is equally shaky and can fall. The stainless steel struc-

tures roof serves little purpose during summer. Firstly, the roof absorbs heat and the overhead roof has to be expanded to provide commuters relief from the scorching heat. The route number boards

should denote the existing route numbers: 49, 49X, 49K, 49F, A47, 78, and 19. Zone 13 (Adyar) of the Greater Chennai Corporation should provide a new shelter at Anna University haltover.

Works of 18 artists on display

Works of 18 well-known and emerging artists are showcased at Art Cube Gallery in Virugambakkam. Titled 'First Impressions' – a celebration of original art, emerging talent, and artistic excellence, this is the debut exhibition at this gallery.

Featuring paintings, sculptures, mixed-media works, photography, serigraphs, folk art, abstracts, limited-edition prints, and collector exclusives, First Impressions offers visitors an encounter with artistic innovation and craftsmanship, said a release.

Another feature of the gallery is its artist-led curation approach. Each exhibition is shaped around carefully selected artists whose originality, dedication, and creative vision have earned recognition through national and international exhibitions and platforms, said the release.

The 18 artists include A. V. Ilango, Asma Menon, Dakshayani B., Dhiyaneshwaran VR, Hemalatha, Jacob Jebaraj, Karthikeyan Pitchaimallian, K.G. Narendrababu, Manisha Raju, N. K. Baskaran, N. S. Manoharan, Raju Durshettiwar, S. Saravanan, Saroja Ravi, Selva Senthil Kumar, Thejomaye Menon and Varalakshmi B.

Beyond exhibitions, Art Cube Gallery would host sip-and-paint experiences, artist residency programmes and art appreciation events.

The exhibition is on till June 10; 10 a.m. to 5 p.m and is free for all. Art Cube Gallery is at Plot 13, 2nd Street, Elango Nagar, Virugambakkam. For details, call Aishna at 9444118484 / 9360200520

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C.T. Natesan, captain of Santhome Higher Secondary School receiving the T.N.C.A. Silver Jubilee Trophy from R.B. Alaganan, vice president, T.N.C.A. in 1983; and former Santhome coach Srinivasa Rao with cricketer Sai Sudharsan.
PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHAN

When two Santhome school watchers meet, cricket enters their conversation as surely as weather does when two Englishmen have a chat. The topic for this column came up on the sidelines of a discussion about the Golden Jubilee Reunion of 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School slated for June 7. While sifting through the accomplishments of the 1976 batch, the inevitable question was asked: "Any alumni from the 1976 batch made it to the national or state cricket team?" In the 1970s, Santhome school was on the way to cricketing greatness, but not until the mid-1980s would it be spoken of in glowing terms for its cricket. From the 1980s, the school produced cricketing giants who have embellished Tamil Nadu and India teams. Never mind that the 1976 batch cannot contribute to the topic. Recollections of Santhome cricket's golden decades seem to have perennial topicality never paling on Madras nostalgia hunters, even if the memory synapse fires from the 1980s.

T20 before T20 arrived

Before the T20 fever gripped cricket aficionados, Santhome Higher Secondary School was in the grip of an even more truncated form of cricket. Practice matches were always clipped short, often into one-fourth the span of the current T20 match, encouraging players to go hell for leather and the bowlers to "deliver" in the ridiculously few deliveries they got to bowl. "Players were trained to score quickly and make every over count," recalls former coach Srinivasa Rao. The sense of urgency while wielding the willow as well as the leather was particularly evident in the 1983-84 season, when at the Swami

Santhome cricket lore never runs out of fizz

The 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School will be in the spotlight today, its members having a gala Golden Jubilee Reunion on the campus. Never mind that none of the alumni from this batch made it to either the state or national team; the occasion still warrants a toast to the school's cricketing culture. Retro Route tracks the high points of the institution's cricketing history

Vivekananda Tournament, the finals was an all-Santhome affair. The school had entered two teams, Santhome 'A' and Santhome 'B', and these teams set up the summit clash. How they made it to the finals is in itself a plot that a 17th century writer from England would give his goose feather quill-wielding arm for. The finals left Santhome's cheerleaders in the gallery in a peculiar situation. In fact, the spectator zone was largely occupied by Santhomeans. When a boundary was hit, there was only cheers, no frowns. When a wicket fell, again only cheer, no glick faces at all, except for those of the opponents on the field. After all, the trophy was intact from the very beginning, sealed for Santhome; the spectators' fingernails were intact too, no nail-chewing nervousness.

Old bonds stay strong

You can take someone out of Santhome, but not Santhome out of them, according to Srinivasa Rao. He does not coach Santhome school anymore, but continues to feel a strong pull towards those gates. Every day, on his walk, he stops by the school and shares a word or two of cricketing wisdom

with the boys slugging it out in a routine practice match.

An unusual admission policy

Behind Santhome's cricketing dominance stood a group of people who put cricket on a pedestal. While recalling those Halcyon days, P. Unnikrishnan, the renowned playback singer and proud Santhomean, speaks fondly about then principal Brother Camillus, whose affection for cricket was impossible to miss. With a laugh, Unnikrishnan remembers how Brother Camillus had a unique yet simple admission policy that was at loggerheads with commonly followed protocols. "If one could play cricket, the rest could be sorted out later." Things were as simple as that in Brother Camillus's world. And that meant Unnikrishnan's report card from his previous school, Asan Memorial, stayed unseen. Unnikrishnan and Santhome had met mid-way, he looking for an environment conducive for growing his skills as a top-order batsman and a wicket keeper, and the school seeking a talent that would slot smoothly into a cricket restructuring plan it had drawn up. Unnikrishnan points out that the school was restructuring its cricket programme in the early 1980s. It did not take long for the institution to see results on account of this exercise.

"We won almost every tournament in the 1980s," he notes. According to the musician, part of Santhome's cricketing success in the 1980s derived from a scientific approach to the sport, partly epitomised by S. Ramakrishnan who

would later come to be known for his pioneering work in video and data analytics in cricket. "Ramakrishnan was my senior by a year and my captain in the Santhome team," the singer says. Today, the role of the support staff is often underlined when a team excels; Santhome has a robust support team, and Unnikrishnan has laudatory words for a few of them, including coach CPS Mani and Md. Hussain (manager of Santhome cricket team), who actually spotted Unnikrishnan's cricketing talent and brought him to Santhome. Champion teams win laurels not only by the strength of their own abilities, but also those of their arch rivals, clashes with them sharpening their skills. Unnikrishnan names Santhome's prime rivals in the 1980s: its neighbour on Santhome High Road, St. Bede's and The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane.

Santhomeans of 1976 to celebrate golden jubilee reunion today

The 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School will celebrate its Golden Jubilee Reunion on June 7 from 4 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. at the school auditorium.

As part of the celebrations, the alumni batch will donate 12 smart boards to their alma mater. The smart boards will be inaugurated during the function, says a press release.

The batch has also taken the initiative to establish and register an alumni association and launch a dedicated website to facilitate online membership registration and related banking transactions for alumni activities.

The 1976 batch originally comprised around 130 students across one English-medium section and two Tamil-medium

sections. Through extensive efforts, the organisers identified 65 former students, who are now connected through a WhatsApp group. Sadly, around 25 batchmates are no longer with them, the release adds.

The reunion is expected to draw nearly 80 alumni members along with their family members.

A special feature of the event will be the felicitation of 11 former teaching staff members and two office assistants who served the batch during their school years.

The event will also be attended by members of the newly formed Alumni Association committee, selected members of the current school staff, and invited senior and junior alumni of the institution.

Retro Route is a column that resurfaces the past that was Madras

Elders care centre launched



Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospital has launched Dr. K Elder Care Assisted Living.

Located in Nanganallur, the centre aims to address the growing need for professional elder care, assisted living, and post-hospital recovery services.

Dr. V. S. Natarajan, founder of Dr. V. S. Natarajan Geriatric Foundation, inaugurated the centre.

According to a press release, the facility offers a comprehensive range of services, including long-term assisted living, post-hospital recovery care, neuro-rehabilitation, palliative and end-of-life care, and respite care.

The facility is designed to provide a safe, comfortable, and medically supervised environment for senior citizens and patients requiring rehabilitation and ongoing support, the release added.

The facilities include doctor consultation suites, nursing supervision, physiotherapy services, medication management, wellness programs, and recreational spaces.

Dr. T. G. Sivaranjani, director, Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, says, "We have created a nurturing environment where seniors can live with dignity, comfort, safety, and access to professional medical support whenever needed."

The Dr. K Elder Care Assisted Living Center in Nanganallur.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Awareness drive on fire safety



The Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Services Department organised an awareness programme on safe measures to prevent fire accidents for residents of Velachery. It was held on June 6 and 7. Residents from Annai Indira Nagar and surrounding neighbourhoods took part.

Exhibition of multilingual picture books

The Library at Goethe-Institut/Max Mueller Bhavan Chennai is conducting an "immersive exploration of big questions in life through children's literature". The event titled 'Litsophical' features a curated exhibition by Rhea Kuthoore and Jigar Bhalani, facilitators of Philosophy with Children.



Participants will also be taken around an exhibition featuring multilingual picture books and thought-provoking questions and activities that engage with the philosophical self.

Litsophical is happening from June 10 to June 20 at Goethe-Institut, Ruthland Gate, 5th Street, Nungambakkam.

For details and to register, WhatsApp 9342267878 or 8816933078 (Rhea)

Nominations invited for Teachers' Awards

The Shiv Nadar Foundation, in partnership with Said Business School, University of Oxford, has invited entries for the inaugural edition of 'India's Best Teachers' Awards 2026'. The awards are for educators of Geography, Business Studies and Entrepreneurship, Computer Science, Economics, Physics, English, Environmental Sciences, and Mathematics, teaching classes IX to XII.

Applications will be assessed on subject expertise, innovation in teaching methodology, impact on student learning outcomes, and leadership within schools and commu-

ities, stated a release from the foundation. School principals and heads of government and private schools can submit nominations until July 31 to <https://indiateacherawards.evalato.com/>

Shortlisted finalists will be invited to participate in the final stage of the awards process at Shiv Nadar University, New Delhi - New Capital Region on September 4 and 5.

Award recipients will receive national recognition and a fully funded scholarship to participate in a one-week learning and development programme at Said Business School.

Course on Montessori teacher training

The Indian Montessori Training Courses (IMTC), Chennai, will commence their 56th Montessori Primary Teacher Training Course later this month.

The course will include online and in-person sessions, a format designed to balance work, family, and a passion for early childhood education. The course will conclude in March 2027.

The successful candidates will be

awarded a diploma by the Indian Montessori Center, Bengaluru.

As an introduction, IMTC-Chennai is holding a brief online orientation and walk-in demo sessions for aspiring teachers between June 8 and 12.

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